



The Ceiling That Also Rose

Redefining Enrolment Headroom Under a Simultaneous Cap-and-Growth Mandate

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Background

A school under an admissions cap and a growth target at once has two ways to satisfy both: change enrolment, or change what “headroom” means.

Aims

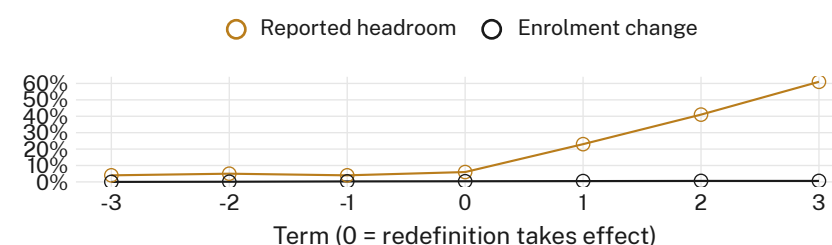
- Test whether a redefined headroom indicator changes admissions behaviour or only its reading
- Compare reported headroom against unadjusted enrolment counts across the redefinition
- Establish whether the two mandates were ever structurally in tension

Methods

- n = 2 Schools · 6 consecutive terms (3 pre-, 3 post-redefinition) · term-end enrolment census
- Headroom recomputed under the amended definition: capacity ahead of forecast demand, not capacity ahead of enrolment
- Offer rate and published admissions cap held constant across the transition as controls

Results

Reported headroom rose sharply across the transition while enrolment counts and offer rates held near constant, consistent with a definitional rather than operational shift.



Reported headroom rose from 4% to 61% between Term -3 and Term +3 across both Schools; enrolment moved by 0.6% over the same period (n = 2 Schools, 6 terms).

Discussion & conclusions

The redefinition satisfies the cap and the growth target from the same unchanged enrolment count: headroom is now read against forecast demand rather than desk capacity. Whether the two mandates were ever in tension, or only appeared so under the prior definition, remains open. Next: extend the comparison once a third School's forecast-demand model is calibrated.

References

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Enrolment census figures drawn from published aggregate reporting; no individual enrolment record retained. Supported by a School of Emergent Priorities seed grant.



“Headroom rose without a single additional desk.”

Reported headroom climbed from 4% to 61% while enrolment moved by 0.6% (n = 2 Schools, 6 terms).